PREFACE

BOTH OF us were in our teens.

He was on a lush ground in Nairobi, running his gloves through the hair flopping over his eyes, glancing over his shoulder like someone had thrown a rock at him from the stands behind square leg. This would become his habit over the years: his nervous, over-the-shoulder twitch, as if an enemy sniper was lurking in the stands.

I was at economics tuition, in a dingy Karachi high-rise.

He started.

I stopped studying – we all did – as that 37-ball century we had heard about unfolded on the TV screen.

They weren't showing the match live. But it didn't matter.

In those 37 balls, a new era of the game cleaved. A new approach birthed.

From a snowy, static-lined TV, he formed a collective memory for all of us in that room. In so many rooms.

Nerds and jocks, babes and bums, all economists about to graduate from private school, all college-bound, all hoping for early success, saw it happen in real time to a middle-class kid from 'across the bridge' in Karachi.

One of the girls said he was cute. One of the jocks noted that he wasn't classy. They didn't matter. Nobody was listening.

In those 37 balls, an imperfect hero, a street-hustling Pathan from the wrong side of the tracks, recreated stardom in the gentleman's game.

The glue was his disrespect for tradition.

His lonesomeness was his weapon. He would hone it.

There was no *sajda* when he hit 100. No humble prostration before the Almighty by kissing the ground. No worship or thanks. There was no bat raise, no helmet in the air.

There wasn't even any acknowledgement of the dressing room, where his teammates were on their feet.

There was a jerk, his blade reloaded like a shotgun, and a march back to the crease that almost took out the stumps as he went back to work.

The Butcher. The Beast. The Boy Wonder. The Boom Boom.

Our game, his way. That's what he played.

And we would let him have his way.

Over hundreds of transmissions, I would see him fly, soar, crash and burn.

And then we would meet, exactly twenty years later, on another hot afternoon, in another battleground: his birthplace, the mountains of Khyber Pass.